

A robot-served café should prove repeat demand before it scales

Restaurant supply supports a testable concept, but this inventory cannot settle the investment case. Keep service format and capacity open to customer choice; earn the right to expand through a measured pilot.

9,651

listed venues in the dataset

38.1%

chain share among classified venues

3

capacity scenarios to test, not preselect

Investment question: can a differentiated service model convert initial curiosity into repeat visits and durable unit economics?

MARKET STRUCTURE

Restaurants dominate the recorded mix

Restaurants make up three quarters of listed venues; cafés account for 4.5%. This is a map of recorded supply, not a measure of customer demand or market value.



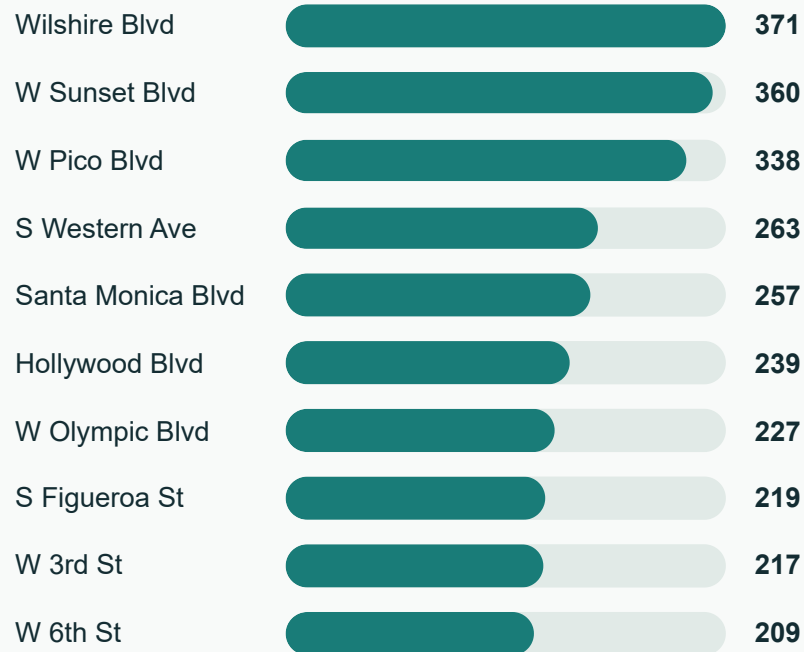
Type	Venues	Share
Restaurant	7,255	75.2%
Fast food	1,066	11.0%
Café	435	4.5%
Pizzeria	320	3.3%
Bar	292	3.0%
Bakery	283	2.9%

Shares use all 9,651 source records and are rounded. The three records with missing chain status remain in the type mix.

A café concept enters a smaller recorded category. Investment must rest on a specific occasion, location and retention case—not category size alone.

STREET CONCENTRATION

Restaurant locations cluster along major corridors



574

streets have exactly one listed venue after address parsing.

The top corridors are Wilshire Blvd (371), W Sunset Blvd (360) and W Pico Blvd (338). Street names were parsed from address text after removing leading numbers and common unit suffixes; results are indicative, not geocoded.

Dense corridors offer visibility and choice. Capacity varies across them, so test rent, foot traffic and café comparables at block level before site selection.

A single listed venue does not establish unmet demand or a commercially attractive “white space.”

Existing café chains provide a reference range, not a target

38.1%

of venues with known chain status are chains (3,676 chain locations; 5,972 independent venues).

All cafés in the dataset

435 venues · mean 25 seats · 50th percentile 21 seats

Confirmed café-chain cohort

266 chain-coded cafés · recorded capacity spans 1–143 seats

Central observed range

Middle 50%: 12–36.75 seats · median 22 seats

Venue type	Mean seats
Restaurant	48.0
Bar	44.8
Fast food	31.8
Pizzeria	28.5
Café	25.0
Bakery	21.8

A name-based match outside the café category is only a manual-review lead; it is not counted as a confirmed café competitor.

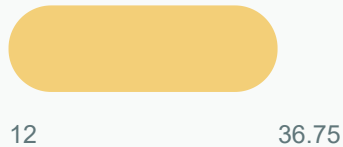
The observed minimum and maximum describe this cohort. They are not recommended capacity limits. Test compact, midpoint and larger formats against site economics and customer choice.

CAPACITY AS A TESTABLE CHOICE

Seat count alone does not identify a café opportunity

The middle half of confirmed café-chain locations contains 12–36.75 seats. This range is a comparator for pilot design, not a prescription.

Middle 50% of observed café chains



Compact: below local median

Midpoint: around local median

Larger: above local median

Among other venues with valid seat counts, 41.8% fall within this central range. Seat count has a very weak association with confirmed café-chain membership (Spearman $\rho = -0.045$); capacity alone is a poor classifier.

TEST 1 · COMPACT

Robot-led, human help available

Lower fixed exposure; test workflow, service quality and peak throughput. Keep an accessible staff fallback.

TEST 2 · MID-SIZED

Hybrid service with clear choice

Compare robot and staff assistance by wait time, satisfaction, repeat visits and operating cost.

TEST 3 · LARGER

Three service modes

Allow robot-led, hybrid or staff-led service. Test groups and peak capacity only with site-level demand evidence.

Measure persistence, then replicate

Pilot gates

Repeat visits after launch incentives end
Seat utilization by daypart
Service time and queue abandonment
Robot interventions, uptime and safety
Labor cost per cover and contribution margin
Customer preference, satisfaction and accessibility

Network thesis

Chains comprise 38.1% of classified venues, showing that multi-location operations are established in this market. It does not show that this concept can scale profitably.

Expand when one unit demonstrates reliable service and attractive economics through ordinary weeks, across customer groups and service modes.

Decision today: fund a measured pilot with three capacity scenarios and meaningful customer choice. Select a footprint only after observed behavior and site economics support it.

Limitations: no sales, rents, traffic, customer preferences, opening dates, robot cost or reliability measures. The inventory is descriptive context, not a forecast.

The pooled seat gap changes after type is considered

Across all types, chain venues average 39.7 seats and independents 46.2 (difference: -6.5). Bakeries have no independent comparator, so the like-for-like comparison below uses the five types with both statuses.

Venue type	Independent mean	Chain mean	Chain – independent
Restaurant	49.5	44.9	-4.7
Fast food	23.6	38.1	$+14.5$
Café	23.6	25.9	$+2.4$
Pizzeria	31.3	25.5	-5.8
Bar	46.4	40.3	-6.1

Simpson check: the pooled difference in the five comparable types is -5.0 seats; an equal-type-weight sensitivity is approximately 0.0 . Within-type differences point in both directions, so this is not a classic, consistent Simpson reversal.

Interpretation: type composition affects the aggregate and effects are heterogeneous. Do not generalize that chains need fewer seats. Means describe listed capacity, not occupancy or returns.

Wordstat can guide validation; no Los Angeles volume is verified yet

Pending

Query-level data require an authenticated Yandex account. No Los Angeles search counts were visible in this review, so no search-volume estimate is reported.

Planned phrases: “coffee shop Los Angeles”; “cafe Los Angeles”; “robot cafe Los Angeles”; “robot restaurant Los Angeles”. Where available, select Los Angeles/California, compare monthly dynamics over two years, and inspect related queries and city-level affinity.

Yandex states that its interface requires sign-in and provides regional/city query breakdowns and query dynamics. Guide: yandex.com/support2/wordstat/en/interface/new · API requirements: yandex.com/support2/wordstat/en/content/api-wordstat

Record for each query

Exact phrase · selected geography · date · monthly counts · share of Yandex queries · affinity index · related phrases

Investor interpretation

Yandex queries are one platform-specific signal. They do not equal total U.S. demand, pedestrian traffic, willingness to pay or proof of repeat purchase.

Triangulate before investing

Combine any authenticated Wordstat export with customer interviews, corridor footfall, competitor visits and observed pilot retention.